RAJASTHANI COLLECTION

NO. 04



RAJASTHAN ORIGIN

Panchmel Dal

Five-Lentil Blend

The Hearty Heart of a Rajasthani Thali

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Panchmel Dal

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Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Panchmel Dal

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Strength in Five Different Lentils

"Panch" means five in Hindi, and panchmel dal lives up to its name by combining five distinct lentils — typically chana dal, toor dal, moong dal, urad dal, and masoor dal — into a single, deeply layered dal that delivers more complexity and nutritional variety than any single lentil could achieve alone. This isn't a random combination; each lentil contributes its own texture and subtle flavor, from chana dal's slight bite to moong dal's creamy softness, building a dal with genuine depth in every spoonful.

The dish is inseparable from dal baati churma, Rajasthan's most famous culinary export, where panchmel dal serves as the savory, protein-rich counterpart to baked baati and sweet churma — together forming a complete, nutritionally balanced meal that historically sustained desert communities through demanding physical labor and long journeys.

Beyond its role alongside baati, panchmel dal stands perfectly well as its own dish, served with rice or roti for an everyday Rajasthani meal, valued for the kind of substantial, warming comfort that a five-lentil blend can provide in a way a single-lentil dal simply can't match.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Strength in Five Different Lentils, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

The traditional savory accompaniment to dal baati churma, one of Rajasthan's most recognized culinary exports. Combines five distinct lentils, each contributing its own texture and flavor, reflecting a deliberate approach to building nutritional and textural complexity. Historically valued for its substantial, protein-rich nutrition, important for communities facing physical labor and long desert journeys. Enjoyed both as part of the full dal baati churma meal and as a standalone everyday dish with rice or roti.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	35m	6	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker
- Kadai or pan, for the tempering
- Whisk

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Panchmel dal keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and, like most dals, tastes good even better the next day. It freezes well for up to 2 months, making it a practical make-ahead component for a larger dal baati churma meal.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the lentils

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Chana dal (split Bengal gram)	3 tbsp	35 g	3 chammach
Toor dal (split pigeon pea)	3 tbsp	35 g	3 chammach
Moong dal (split, yellow)	3 tbsp	35 g	3 chammach
Urad dal (split, dehusked)	3 tbsp	30 g	3 chammach
Masoor dal (split red lentil)	3 tbsp	30 g	3 chammach
Water, for cooking	4 cups	1 L	4 katori
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	1¼ tsp	7.5 g	to taste

For the tempering

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Dried red chili	2	2	2
Onion, finely chopped	1 small	80 g	1 small
Ginger-garlic paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the tempering (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Tomato, chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Red chili powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Garam masala	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

All five lentils are widely available at Indian grocers, usually sold individually, and increasingly in the international aisle of general supermarkets. If one variety is unavailable, the dish still works well with four lentils, or by increasing the quantity of the others slightly — the specific five-way balance is traditional but not strictly rigid in everyday cooking.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Five Lentils

01 RINSE ALL THE LENTILS TOGETHER

Combine all five lentils in a bowl and rinse thoroughly until the water runs mostly clear.

02 PRESSURE COOK UNTIL SOFT

Transfer to a pressure cooker with water, turmeric, and salt. Cook for 4–5 whistles, until all the lentils are completely soft.



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Cooking the Five Lentils, continued

Chef tip. the different lentils cook at slightly different rates, but pressure cooking together works well, with the firmer chana dal holding a little more texture than the others — this contrast is part of the dish's appeal.

03 WHISK LIGHTLY

Once cooked, whisk the dal lightly — just enough to combine everything into a cohesive mixture without mashing it completely smooth, preserving some texture from the different lentils.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

All five lentils should be soft and tender, though a light whisk should still reveal some textural variation between the different types rather than a completely uniform puree.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Tempering

04 BLOOM THE CUMIN

Heat ghee in a kadai and add cumin seeds, asafoetida, and dried red chilies, letting them sizzle until fragrant.

05 SAUTÉ THE ONION

Add the chopped onion and cook until golden, about 6–7 minutes. Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant.

06 ADD TOMATO AND SPICES

Add the chopped tomato, chili powder, and coriander powder. Cook for 6–8 minutes, until the tomato softens and the oil separates slightly at the edges.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Tempering, continued



07 COMBINE WITH THE DAL

Pour the tempering into the cooked lentils, stirring to combine thoroughly. Simmer together for 8–10 minutes, adding water as needed to reach your preferred consistency. Finish with garam masala.

Texture indicator. panchmel dal should be thick and hearty, coating a spoon well, with a rich golden-brown color from the five lentils combined.

08 GARNISH AND SERVE

Finish with fresh coriander just before serving.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Tempering, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Rushing the onion and tomato tempering stage misses an opportunity to build real depth — take the time to properly soften and lightly caramelize the onion before adding tomato.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served alongside baati and churma as the complete dal baati churma meal.
- Poured over rice or eaten with roti as a hearty standalone dish.

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl or katori as part of a Rajasthani thali platter.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A shared pot at the center of the table, ladled generously over rice or alongside baati for each family member.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Depth Right

- The combination of five different lentils, rather than any single one, is what gives this dal its signature layered texture and flavor.
- A properly developed onion-tomato tempering base adds real depth that a rushed version can't match.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Panchmel dal reheats very well, making it a practical make-ahead component of a larger dal baati churma meal.
- Pre-portion and freeze the five-lentil mix dry for quick future cooking, measuring out the blend in advance.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Rajasthani restaurants finish the dal with a final tempering poured on top just before serving — a second round of sizzling ghee, cumin, and dried chili — for an extra burst of aroma at the table.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

210 kcal	11 g	28 g	6 g	9 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with ghee and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Sesame. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Classic Panchmel Dal	the traditional five-lentil version featured here.
Char Dal (Four-Lentil) Version	a common household adjustment when one lentil variety isn't on hand.
Marwari-Style Panchmel Dal	a regional variation with a slightly different spice emphasis from the Marwar region of Rajasthan.

Can I use fewer than five lentils?

Yes — a four-lentil version works well if one type isn't available; the dish remains delicious with a slightly adjusted balance.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why is my dal too thin or too thick?

Adjust with water — panchmel dal should be thick and hearty, but you can thin it to your preferred consistency during the final simmer.

Is panchmel dal very spicy?

It's moderately spiced, warming rather than fiery — adjust chili powder to your preferred heat level.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Panchmel	Hindi for "five-mixed," describing this dal's combination of five different lentils.
Baati	hard, baked wheat dough balls, the traditional accompaniment to this dal.
Chana Dal	split Bengal gram, one of the five lentils in this blend.
Masoor Dal	split red lentil, another of the five lentils in this blend.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Panchmel Dal

10m	35m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
6	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

LENTILS

Chana dal	35 g
Toor dal	35 g
Moong dal	35 g
Urad dal	30 g
Masoor dal	30 g
Water	1 L
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Salt	7.5 g

TEMPERING

Ghee	45 g
Cumin seeds	4 g
Asafoetida	pinch
Dried red chili	2
Onion	80 g
Ginger-garlic paste	15 g
Tomato	100 g
Red chili powder	3 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Garam masala	1.5 g
Fresh coriander	8 g

METHOD

01 **Rinse all the lentils together.** Combine all five lentils in a bowl and rinse thoroughly until the water runs mostly clear.

02 **Pressure cook until soft.** Transfer to a pressure cooker with water, turmeric, and salt.

03 **Whisk lightly.** Once cooked, whisk the dal lightly — just enough to combine everything into a cohesive mixture without mashing it completely smooth, preserving some texture from the different lentils.

04 **Bloom the cumin.** Heat ghee in a kadai and add cumin seeds, asafoetida, and dried red chilies, letting them sizzle until fragrant.

05 **Sauté the onion.** Add the chopped onion and cook until golden, about 6–7 minutes.

06 **Add tomato and spices.** Add the chopped tomato, chili powder, and coriander powder.

07 **Combine with the dal.** Pour the tempering into the cooked lentils, stirring to combine thoroughly.

08 **Garnish and serve.** Finish with fresh coriander just before serving.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Chana dal	35 g	☐ Toor dal	35 g
☐ Moong dal	35 g	☐ Urad dal	30 g
☐ Masoor dal	30 g	☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Salt	7.5 g	☐ Ghee	45 g
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Asafoetida	pinch
☐ Dried red chili	2	☐ Onion	80 g
☐ Ginger-garlic paste	15 g	☐ Tomato	100 g
☐ Red chili powder	3 g	☐ Coriander powder	3 g
☐ Garam masala	1.5 g	☐ Fresh coriander	8 g

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